

English Grammar

A Comprehensive Reference for IELTS & TOEFL

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This textbook is designed as a practical and in-depth grammar reference for English learners preparing for academic exams (IELTS & TOEFL). It focuses on both explanation and application: rules, examples, exam tips, and practice.

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Preface

This book is written for intermediate to advanced English learners who aim to achieve high scores in standardized academic tests such as **IELTS** and **TOEFL**, and for learners who want a comprehensive, reliable grammar reference. Each chapter includes clear explanations, graded examples, exam tips, and practice exercises.

Exam Tip: Use this book actively: read a section, study the examples, then do the exercises. When preparing for IELTS/TOEFL, focus on accuracy first, range second.

Chapter 1

Foundations of English Grammar

1.1 What is Grammar?

Grammar is the system of rules that governs how words are combined to form sentences. Grammar controls morphology (word forms), syntax (sentence structure), and usage (pragmatic choices).

1.2 Sentence Elements

Definition: A sentence typically contains a **subject** and a **predicate**. The predicate contains the verb and provides information about the subject. Objects, complements, and modifiers add details.

1.2.1 Subject, Predicate, Object, Complement

- **Subject:** the doer or topic of the sentence.
- **Predicate:** includes the verb and expresses something about the subject.
- **Direct object:** receives the action of a transitive verb.
- **Indirect object:** recipient of the direct object.
- **Complement:** completes the meaning of a subject or object (e.g. subject complement after linking verbs).

Example: *The committee* (subject) *approved* (verb) *the proposal* (direct object).

1.3 Word Order in English

English is primarily SVO (Subject-Verb-Object). Word order is crucial for meaning. In questions and some other constructions, inversion occurs.

Chapter 2

Parts of Speech

2.1 Nouns

2.1.1 Types of Nouns

Common, proper, countable, uncountable, collective, abstract.

2.1.2 Countable vs. Uncountable

Definition: Countable nouns have plural forms and can be used with numbers (one book, two books). Uncountable nouns cannot be counted directly (water, information) and take singular verbs.

Example: *Many books* vs. *much information*.

Common Error: Using 'many' with uncountable nouns: *many informations* is incorrect.

2.2 Pronouns

2.2.1 Personal, Possessive, Reflexive

Rules for pronoun agreement and clarity of reference.

Example: *She gave herself a break.*

Common Error: Ambiguous pronouns: avoid unclear antecedents.

2.3 Adjectives and Adverbs

2.3.1 Adjective order

Typical order: Determiner — Opinion — Size — Age — Shape — Color — Origin — Material — Purpose — Noun.

Example: *a lovely small old round wooden jewelry box*

2.3.2 Adverbs: Position and Types

Adverbs of frequency, manner, place, time; typical positions (before main verb for frequency, after main verb for manner, etc.).

Chapter 3

Sentence Structure and Clauses

3.1 Simple, Compound, Complex

Definition: Simple sentence: one independent clause.

Compound sentence: two or more independent clauses joined by coordinating conjunctions (and, but, or, so, yet).

Complex sentence: one independent clause + one or more dependent (subordinate) clauses.

Example: Simple: *She reads.* Compound: *She reads, and he writes.* Complex: *She reads because she enjoys learning.*

3.2 Relative Clauses

Defining vs non-defining clauses; punctuation rules, choice of relative pronoun (who, which, that, whom, where, when).

Example: The book *that* I borrowed was helpful. (defining)
My sister, *who* lives in London, is a teacher. (non-defining)

3.3 Noun Clauses (Nominal Clauses)

Noun clauses function as subjects, objects, or complements. Common introducers: that, whether, if, wh-words.

Example: *What she said* surprised everyone.

3.4 Sentence Fragments and Run-ons

How to identify and correct fragments and comma splices (run-on sentences). Use semicolons, coordinating conjunctions, or restructure clauses.

Chapter 4

Tenses and Aspect

4.1 Understanding Tense vs Aspect

Tense locates an action in time (past, present, future). Aspect shows internal temporal structure (simple, continuous/progressive, perfect, perfect continuous).

4.2 Present Tenses

4.2.1 Present Simple

Use for habitual actions, general truths, scheduled events.

Example: She usually walks to work.

4.2.2 Present Continuous

Use for actions happening now or around now, and future arrangements.

Example: I am studying for the exam.

4.2.3 Present Perfect

Used for actions with relevance to the present: experience, recent events, actions that started in the past and continue to present.

Example: She has lived here since 2010.

4.2.4 Present Perfect Continuous

Focuses on duration of an action up to the present.

Example: They have been studying for three hours.

4.3 Past Tenses

4.3.1 Past Simple

Completed actions at a definite time in the past.

Example: He graduated last year.

4.3.2 Past Continuous

Background actions in the past; parallel actions.

Example: While I was cooking, she called.

4.3.3 Past Perfect

An action completed before another past action.

Example: She had left before I arrived.

4.3.4 Past Perfect Continuous

Duration before a certain past point.

Example: They had been working for two hours when the power went out.

4.4 Future Forms

Will vs going to vs present continuous for future. Future perfect and future continuous explained.

4.5 Tense Harmony and Sequence of Tenses

How tense backshifts in reported speech and conditionals. Importance of consistency for coherence in essays and spoken answers.

Exam Tip: In IELTS Writing Task 1 (Academic), prefer simple and perfect tenses to describe trends. Avoid unnecessary tense shifts.

Chapter 5

Modal Verbs and Auxiliary Structures

5.1 Modal Verbs: basic uses

Can/could, may/might, must, should, ought to, shall/will, would.

5.1.1 Degrees of certainty and politeness

Can vs could, may vs might, must (deduction) vs have to (obligation).

Example: He must be at home. (logical conclusion)
You must finish this by tomorrow. (obligation)

5.2 Semi-modals and Periphrastic forms

Have to, need to, be able to, used to, be supposed to.

Chapter 6

Voice: Active and Passive

6.1 Forming the Passive

All tenses can have passive equivalents. Use auxiliary *be* + past participle.

Example: Active: The committee approved the policy.
Passive: The policy was approved by the committee.

6.2 When to use Passive

To focus on action rather than agent, in academic writing, or when agent is unknown or irrelevant.

Exam Tip: In IELTS Academic Writing Task 1, passive voice can often make descriptions more objective.

Chapter 7

Conditionals and Hypothetical Structures

7.1 Zero, First, Second, Third Conditionals

- Zero: general truths (If + present, present).
- First: possible future (If + present, will + base).
- Second: unreal present/future (If + past simple, would + base).
- Third: unreal past (If + past perfect, would have + past participle).

Example: If you heat water, it boils.

If it rains, I will stay home.

If I won the lottery, I would travel.

If I had known, I would have told you.

7.2 Mixed Conditionals and Wishes

Mixed conditionals combine past and present hypothetical consequences. Use *wish* to express regret or desire with past/present/future reference.

Example: If I had studied harder (past), I would be at university now (present result).

I wish I had gone to the conference.

Chapter 8

Clauses and Advanced Structures

8.1 Relative Clauses: reduction and complexity

Reduced relative clauses, omission of relative pronouns when possible, and restrictive vs nonrestrictive distinctions.

8.2 Inversion for Emphasis

Inversion in negatives and for adverbial expressions for stylistic emphasis.

Example: Rarely have I seen such dedication.

8.3 Cleft and Pseudo-cleft Sentences

It was/what-clefts to emphasize a sentence element. Useful to vary sentence openings in essays.

Example: It was **John** who solved the problem.
What I need is more time.

8.4 Nominalization

Turning verbs and adjectives into nouns to create formal, concise academic style (e.g. *analyze* -> *analysis*).

Exam Tip: Nominalization increases formality and density—use it in academic writing but avoid overuse.

Chapter 9

Reported Speech

9.1 Backshifting and Reporting Verbs

Rules for shifting tenses, pronouns, and time expressions when converting direct speech into reported speech.

Example: Direct: "I am leaving" -> Reported: He said (that) he was leaving.

Chapter 10

Subjunctive and Formal Structures

10.1 Present Subjunctive

Use of subjunctive in formal expressions, demands, suggestions (e.g. "It is essential that he be present").

10.2 Formal registers and fixed expressions

Use of constructions like *lest*, *had I known*, and formal inversion.

Chapter 11

Punctuation, Style and Cohesion

11.1 Articles and Determiners

Usage of a/an, the, zero article; determiners with countable and uncountable nouns.

Example: I bought a car. The car is blue.

11.2 Commas, Semicolons, Colons

Rules to avoid comma splices and to use semicolons and colons effectively.

11.3 Linking words and discourse markers

Phrases for addition, contrast, cause/effect, exemplification, sequencing. Use them to improve cohesion and coherence in essays.

Addition: moreover, furthermore, in addition, besides.

Example: for example, for instance, such

Contrast: however, on the other hand, as,

whereas, although.

Sequencing: firstly, secondly, finally, sub-

Cause/Effect: therefore, consequently, as a result, subsequently.

Exam Tip: Avoid overusing the same linking word. Aim for a varied set of connectors and natural flow.

Chapter 12

Common Errors and How to Avoid Them

12.1 Subject-Verb Agreement

Agreement with singular/plural subjects, collective nouns, and tricky constructions (e.g., "one of the students is/are").

12.2 Article Errors

When to use definite/indefinite/zero articles; common mistakes by L1 speakers.

12.3 Preposition Problems

Common preposition collocations and fixed expressions. Practice lists.

Common Error: Incorrect preposition: *married with* -> correct: *married to*.

Chapter 13

Grammar for IELTS and TOEFL

13.1 What examiners look for

IELTS: Grammatical Range and Accuracy. TOEFL: grammatical control in writing and speaking responses.

13.2 Writing Task 1 (Academic) and Writing Task 2

Task-specific grammar guidance: report trends, use passive where appropriate, vary sentence types, avoid contractions.

13.3 Speaking: Fluency and Accuracy

Balance fluency with grammatical correctness. Use a range of structures but avoid unnatural complexity.

Exam Tip: When practicing speaking, record yourself and transcribe the response to analyze grammar and sentence variety.

Chapter 14

Exercises

Each section below contains short practice activities.

14.1 Error Correction

Correct the errors in the following sentences:

1. She don't like coffee.
2. The informations were useful.
3. If I will see him, I will tell him.
4. He suggested me to go there.
5. This is the man which helped me.

14.2 Transformations

Rewrite the sentences as requested:

1. Change to passive: "They will announce the results tomorrow."
2. Reported speech: "She said, 'I have finished the report.'"
3. Conditional (second): "If I (win) the prize, I (buy) a car."
4. Use a cleft to emphasize "John fixed the car."
5. Reduce the relative clause: "The documents which were signed yesterday are ready."

14.3 Tense Practice

Fill in the correct tense:

1. By next year, I (finish) my degree.
2. She (study) French for three years before she moved to Paris.
3. Right now, they (work) on the new project.

Answer Key

Error Correction Answers

1. She doesn't like coffee.
2. The information was useful. (information is uncountable)
3. If I see him, I will tell him. (first conditional) or If I saw him, I would tell him. (second conditional)
4. He suggested that I go there. / He suggested going there.
5. This is the man who helped me. (use "who")

Transformations Answers

1. The results will be announced tomorrow.
2. She said (that) she had finished the report.
3. If I won the prize, I would buy a car.
4. It was John who fixed the car.
5. The documents signed yesterday are ready.

Tense Practice Answers

1. will have finished
2. had been studying
3. are working / are working on

Appendix: Useful Tables

Timeline of Tenses

Tense	Use / Example
Present Simple	habits, facts: She works every day.
Present Continuous	actions now, arrangements: He is leaving tomorrow.
Present Perfect	experience/continuing: She has lived here since 2010.
Past Simple	finished past: They visited last summer.
Past Perfect	past before past: She had left when I arrived.
Future (will)	predictions/decisions: I will help you.